

# Notes: Bertrand, Kamenica, and Pan (QJE, 2015)

## Gender Identity and Relative Income within Households

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# 1 Big picture

- **Question.** Does the gender norm that “a man should earn more than his wife” affect who marries whom, wives’ labor supply, marital stability, and the division of home production inside marriage?
- **Setting.** The paper studies U.S. households using several complementary datasets: SIPP linked to SSA/IRS administrative earnings data, U.S. Census and ACS data, the National Survey of Families and Households (NSFH), the American Time Use Survey (ATUS/CPS), and the Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID).
- **Core challenge.** A simple difference in spousal earnings could reflect many forces other than gender identity: assortative matching, specialization, bargaining, child rearing, or omitted couple characteristics. The paper therefore needs evidence that the threshold where the wife starts earning *more* than the husband has special economic content.
- **Main contribution.** The paper documents a sharp discontinuity in the distribution of relative income exactly at one-half, shows that standard marriage-market models do not naturally generate such a cliff, and then traces the consequences of this norm through marriage formation, female labor supply, marital satisfaction, divorce, and housework.
- **Why it matters.** The paper links household behavior to identity norms rather than only prices and technology. It offers one explanation for why the narrowing of gender gaps in labor outcomes may stall even after women experience large gains in education and wages.
- **Main empirical idea.**
  - Start with the basic fact that the distribution of the wife’s income share drops sharply when the wife would begin to out-earn the husband.
  - Show that this discontinuity is stronger where traditional gender attitudes are likely stronger.
  - Test whether environments or couples in which the wife is more likely to earn more than the husband exhibit lower marriage rates, lower female labor supply, worse marriage outcomes, and more housework by wives.
  - Check whether the same patterns appear *within couples over time*.
- **Main results.**
  - In the SIPP administrative data, the distribution of the wife’s share of household income drops by about **12.3%** just to the right of one-half.
  - In Census/ACS data, the corresponding drop is about **13.6%**.
  - The discontinuity is much stronger among less-educated couples: about **20.1%** for low-education couples versus only **5.53%** for more-educated couples.
  - In marriage-market regressions, a rise in the probability that a randomly drawn woman would earn more than a randomly drawn man lowers the marriage rate; the preferred Bartik-based estimate implies that changing relative income explains about **29%** of the decline in marriage rates from 1980 to 2010.
  - Among married couples, wives are less likely to participate in the labor force when they are more likely to out-earn their husbands.

- Among working wives, realized income is lower relative to potential income when the wife is more likely to out-earn the husband.
- Couples in which the wife earns more than the husband are less satisfied, more likely to report marital trouble, more likely to discuss separation, and more likely to divorce.
- In such couples, wives also do **more** nonmarket work, not less.
- Panel evidence from the PSID broadly confirms these patterns within couples over time.
- **Economic takeaway.** Gender identity acts like a household-level distortion. As women’s market opportunities improve, couples may respond by changing marriage decisions, suppressing wives’ labor supply or earnings, and reallocating chores in ways that preserve traditional breadwinner roles.

## 2 Data and measurement (key objects)

### 2.1 Relative-income distribution data

- **Administrative distribution evidence.** The paper uses the SIPP linked to SSA/IRS earnings data, 1990–2004.
- **Sample.** Married couples, both spouses age 18–65, both with positive income.
- **Observation rule.** For each couple, the paper keeps the first year the couple appears in the panel.
- **Sample size.** 73,654 couple-level observations.
- **Main variable.** Relative income is the wife’s share of labor and self-employment income:

$$\text{relativeIncome}_i = \frac{\text{wifeIncome}_i}{\text{wifeIncome}_i + \text{husbIncome}_i}.$$

### 2.2 Census and ACS data for broad descriptive evidence

- **Sources.** 1970–2000 U.S. Censuses and ACS 2008–2011.
- **Unit.** Household head and spouse.
- **Cleaning problem.** Census/ACS data have an artificial spike at one-half due to top-coding, imputation, single-respondent reporting, and rounding.
- **Cleaning solution.**
  - drop couples with imputed income;
  - drop couples where both spouses are top-coded;
  - scale one-sided top-coded income by 1.5;
  - “de-round” the remaining exact-half cases except for the small fraction consistent with the administrative data.

## 2.3 Marriage-market data and market definition

- **Main source for marriage-market regressions.** 1980, 1990, 2000 U.S. Census and 2008–2011 ACS.
- **Marriage market definition.** Markets are defined by **race**  $\times$  **age group**  $\times$  **education group**  $\times$  **state**.
- **Race groups.** Non-Hispanic white, non-Hispanic black, Hispanic.
- **Age groups.**
  - women 22–31 matched with men 24–33,
  - women 32–41 matched with men 34–43,
  - women 42–51 matched with men 44–53.
- **Education groups.**
  - high school or less,
  - some college or more.
- **Empirical support.** About **59%** of marriages occur within the same market under this definition.

## 2.4 Women’s labor-supply data and potential income

- **Source.** 1970–2000 Census and ACS 2008–2011.
- **Sample restriction.** Married couples where the husband is working.
- **Potential income construction.** For each wife, the paper constructs percentiles of positive earnings among working women in the same demographic cell defined by race, five-year age group, education category, and state.
- **Potential-income object.** For  $p \in \{5, 10, \dots, 95\}$ , let  $w_i^p$  be the  $p$ th percentile of positive earnings in the wife’s demographic group.
- **Key probability.**  $\text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i$  measures the probability that the wife’s earnings would exceed the husband’s if her income were randomly drawn from that distribution.
- **Summary facts.**
  - Mean  $\text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i$  is about **0.18**.
  - It rises from about **0.09** in 1970 to **0.27** in the 2010 ACS.
  - About **67%** of wives participate in the labor force in the pooled sample.

## 2.5 Marriage quality, divorce, and home production data

- **Marriage quality and divorce.** NSFH Waves 1 and 2 (1987–88 and 1992–94), about **4,000** married couples, at least one spouse with positive labor income.

- **Outcomes.**
  - `happyMarriage`: indicator for reporting the marriage as “very happy”;
  - `marriageTrouble`: indicator for saying the marriage might be in trouble;
  - `discussSeparation`: indicator for discussing separation;
  - `divorced`: indicator for separation or divorce by Wave 2.
- **Home production.** ATUS/CPS 2003–2011.
- **Home-production measure.** Weekly hours in chores, obtaining goods and services, other home production, and childcare.
- **Descriptive fact.** Wives spend about **36** hours per week on chores and childcare, versus **22.5** hours for husbands.
- **Relative income in ATUS/CPS.** Wife earns more in about **25%** of couples.

## 2.6 Panel data

- **Source.** PSID family files (1968–2009) and marital history file.
- **Use.** Allows the paper to move from cross-sectional comparisons to **within-couple** changes in relative income.
- **Main outcomes in panel.**
  - wife labor force participation,
  - divorce,
  - wife housework minus husband housework.

## 2.7 Key descriptive facts

- The wife earns more than the husband in **27%** of couples in ACS 2008–2011.
- The discontinuity in the distribution at the 0.5 threshold is present in every decade:
  - 1970: **20.6%**,
  - 1980: **26.2%**,
  - 1990: **24.4%**,
  - 2000: **10.8%**,
  - ACS 2008–2011: **10.0%**.
- The discontinuity is present both with and without children:
  - with children: **15.2%**,
  - without children: **11.6%**.
- The discontinuity is already present among newlyweds and tends to grow with marriage tenure over the first decade.

## 2.8 Unobservables and interpretation issues

- A key concern is **selection**: women willing to marry lower-income men may differ in unobservable ways that also affect labor force participation, earnings, or marital stability.
- Another concern is that standard marriage models predict smooth effects of relative positions, not a discrete break when the wife passes the husband.
- The paper addresses these issues by:
  - comparing actual, predicted, and Bartik-predicted income distributions;
  - controlling flexibly for the full distributions of male and female earnings;
  - controlling for relative income at marriage where possible;
  - checking whether results survive within-couple fixed effects in panel data.

## 3 Models and empirical specifications (all equations + interpretation)

### 3.1 Relative income and the core descriptive object

The paper's first object is the wife's share of household income:

$$\text{relativeIncome}_i = \frac{\text{wifeIncome}_i}{\text{wifeIncome}_i + \text{husbIncome}_i}.$$

The empirical fact is a **discontinuity** in the density of  $\text{relativeIncome}_i$  at  $1/2$ .

**Interpretation.** If couples were allocated smoothly by standard economic forces, one would not expect the density of relative income to drop exactly when the wife begins to out-earn the husband. The cliff at one-half is therefore the core reduced-form fact the rest of the paper tries to explain.

### 3.2 Marriage-market probability that a woman earns more than a man

For each marriage market  $m$  and year  $t$ , the paper defines the probability that a randomly chosen woman would out-earn a randomly chosen man:

$$\text{PrWomanEarnsMore}_{mt} = \Pr(w_i > h_j).$$

Operationally, this is computed by drawing **50,000** women and men with replacement from the relevant market distributions and calculating the share of random couples for which the woman's income exceeds the man's.

**Interpretation.** This is the market-level object that matters for *marriage formation*. It does not ask whether a given married wife currently earns more than her husband; it asks how likely that situation is in the local market from which matches are drawn.

### 3.3 Marriage-market regression

The baseline marriage-market specification is:

$$\text{shareMarried}_{mt} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 \text{PrWomanEarnsMore}_{mt} + \alpha_2 X_{mt} + \varepsilon_{mt},$$

where:

- $\text{shareMarried}_{mt}$  is the share of men currently married in market  $m$  at time  $t$ ;
- $X_{mt}$  includes rich controls:
  - logs of average female and male income,
  - deciles of male and female income distributions,
  - marriage-market fixed effects,
  - year fixed effects interacted with race, age group, education, and state,
  - in richer specifications: sex ratio, incarceration rates, average schooling, and counts of men and women.

**Interpretation.** A negative  $\alpha_1$  means that marriage becomes less common when the local relative income distribution makes it more likely that wives would out-earn husbands. In the preferred Bartik-based specification, the coefficient is about  $-0.351$ .

### 3.4 Predicted earnings and the Bartik instrument

The paper constructs **predicted** distributions of earnings by demographic cells to separate relative-income variation from endogenous labor supply.

The Bartik-style instrument for average wages by gender and marriage market is:

$$\hat{w}_{mt}^g = \sum_j \lambda_{rejs,1980}^g w_{reajt,-s}^g,$$

where:

- $g$  indexes gender,
- $r$  race,
- $e$  education,
- $a$  age group,
- $j$  industry,
- $s$  state.

Here,

- $\lambda_{rejs,1980}^g$  is the 1980 state-industry employment share for gender-race-education cells,
- $w_{reajt,-s}^g$  is the national wage for that demographic group in industry  $j$ , excluding state  $s$ .



The paper then extends this idea to each percentile  $p$  of the earnings distribution:

$$\widehat{w}_{mt}^{g,p} = \sum_j \lambda_{rejs,1980}^g w_{reajt,-s}^{g,p}.$$

**Interpretation.** This is the paper’s main identification device for marriage-market regressions. It uses national industry wage changes, combined with predetermined state-industry composition, to generate plausibly exogenous shifts in local male and female earnings distributions.

### 3.5 Probability that a wife would earn more than her husband

For married couple  $i$ , the paper defines

$$\text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i = \frac{1}{19} \sum_p 1\{w_i^p > \text{husbIncome}_i\},$$

where  $w_i^p$  is the  $p$ th percentile of the wife’s potential earnings distribution, with  $p \in \{5, 10, \dots, 95\}$ .

**Interpretation.** This variable captures how likely it is that the wife’s *potential* income would exceed the husband’s actual income if she were working. It is the key threat-to-identity object in the labor-supply analysis.

### 3.6 Wife labor force participation regression

The core labor-force-participation regression is

$$\text{wifeLFP}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i + \beta_2 \ln(\text{husbIncome}_i) + \beta_3 X_i + \varepsilon_i,$$

with additional flexible controls for the wife’s potential income distribution and, in richer specifications, nonlinear husband-income controls, interactions with the wife’s median potential earnings, child indicators, and husband/wife demographic-group interactions.

**Interpretation.** If  $\beta_1 < 0$ , wives are less likely to work when they are more likely to out-earn their husbands. The baseline coefficient is about  $-0.178$ ; with richer controls it remains around  $-0.14$  to  $-0.15$ . The paper interprets this as distortion of labor supply to avoid gender role reversal.

### 3.7 Gap between potential and realized income

For working wives, the paper defines

$$\text{incomeGap}_i = \frac{\text{wifeIncome}_i - \text{wifePotential}_i}{\text{wifePotential}_i},$$

where  $\text{wifePotential}_i$  is the mean of the wife’s potential earnings distribution.

The regression mirrors the labor-force-participation specification:

$$\text{incomeGap}_i = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i + \gamma_2 X_i + \varepsilon_i.$$

**Interpretation.** If  $\gamma_1 < 0$ , wives who are more likely to out-earn their husbands earn less than their potential even when they do work. This suggests an **intensive-margin** distortion in labor supply or job choice. The paper also shows that part of this works through fewer hours.

### 3.8 Marital satisfaction and divorce regressions

For marital satisfaction and divorce outcomes, the paper estimates linear probability models of the form

$$Y_i = \delta_0 + \delta_1 \text{wifeEarnsMore}_i + \delta_2 \ln(\text{wifeIncome}_i) + \delta_3 \ln(\text{husbIncome}_i) + \delta_4 \ln(\text{totIncome}_i) + \delta_5 X_i + \varepsilon_i,$$

where  $Y_i$  is one of:

- `happyMarriage`,
- `marriageTrouble`,
- `discussSeparation`,
- `divorced`.

The paper then adds two important robustness controls:

- `relativeIncome` itself;
- the absolute difference in husband and wife income ranks in gender-specific distributions.

**Interpretation.** This design asks whether it is the discrete event that the wife becomes the primary breadwinner that matters, or instead a smooth measure of relative earnings. The answer is strongly in favor of the threshold-crossing interpretation.

### 3.9 Home production regression

Because ATUS has only one respondent per household, the paper estimates an interaction model:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{totalNonMarketWork}_i = & \theta_0 + \theta_1 (\text{female}_i \times \text{wifeEarnsMore}_i) + \theta_2 \text{female}_i + \theta_3 \text{wifeEarnsMore}_i \\ & + \theta_4 Z_i + \theta_5 (\text{female}_i \times Z_i) + \varepsilon_i, \end{aligned}$$

where  $Z_i$  includes income controls, year/state/day fixed effects, age polynomials, race and education controls, work-status controls, and in richer specifications children controls and `relativeIncome`.

**Interpretation.** The coefficient on  $\text{female}_i \times \text{wifeEarnsMore}_i$  measures whether the **gender gap** in home production is larger when the wife earns more than the husband. A positive coefficient means wives compensate for role reversal by doing more chores and childcare.

### 3.10 Panel-data specifications

The PSID allows the paper to move from cross-section to within-couple variation.

For labor force participation:

$$\text{wifeLFP}_{it} = \mu_i + \tau_t + \rho \text{wifeEarnsMore}_{i,t-1} + X_{i,t-1} \Gamma + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

For divorce:

$$\text{divorced}_{it} = \mu_i + \tau_t + \rho_1 \text{wifeEarnsMore}_{i,t-1} + \rho_2 \text{wifeEarnsMore}_{i,t-2} + X_{i,t-1,t-2} \Gamma + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

For the gender gap in housework:

$$\text{houseworkGap}_{it} = \mu_i + \tau_t + \psi \text{wifeEarnsMore}_{it} + X_{it}\Gamma + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

**Interpretation.** These specifications ask whether, holding fixed permanent couple heterogeneity, a switch into the state where the wife earns more than the husband predicts subsequent labor-market exit, divorce, or a larger housework gap.

## 4 Identification and instruments (what makes the estimates credible)

### 4.1 What fails in standard marriage models

- **Assortative matching models** match people by rank in gender-specific distributions, not by the absolute threshold where the wife passes the husband.
- **Comparative-advantage models** imply smooth changes in gains from specialization, not a cliff at exactly one-half.
- **Bargaining models** can make relative income matter for outside options, but again do not naturally predict a discontinuous drop exactly at equality.

**Implication.** The observed discontinuity at the point where the wife begins to earn more than the husband is hard to reconcile with standard models alone.

### 4.2 Why the discontinuity points to gender norms

- The density of the wife's income share drops sharply to the right of 1/2.
- The cliff is stronger among less-educated couples, who also report more traditional views in survey data.
- The cliff is present among newlyweds and grows with marriage tenure, consistent with both selection into marriage and within-marriage adjustments.

**Interpretation.** The threshold itself appears behaviorally meaningful, which is exactly what one would expect if there is a norm that the husband should be the primary earner.

### 4.3 Marriage-rate identification

- The OLS marriage-market regressions flexibly control for male and female income distributions, average incomes, market fixed effects, and year-by-demographic interactions.
- The Bartik instrument isolates gender-specific changes in local labor demand using national industry wage growth and predetermined local industry composition.
- The paper's preferred Bartik coefficient remains negative and implies a quantitatively meaningful role for relative income in marriage decline.

**Caveat.** The marriage-rate IV estimates are not as statistically strong as the cross-sectional income-gap evidence, so the strongest claims here should be read as economically important but somewhat more cautious.

#### 4.4 Labor-supply identification and selection concerns

- A major concern is that women who marry lower-income men may have unobserved traits that also reduce labor force participation.
- The coefficient on  $\text{PrWifeEarnsMore}_i$  is stable when the paper adds controls for children and for the full interaction of husband and wife demographic groups.
- In the ACS subsample, controlling for **PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage** and both spouses' potential-income distributions at marriage leaves the result intact.

**Interpretation.** The paper's claim is not that the identifying variation is perfectly experimental, but that several distinct sources of evidence point in the same direction.

#### 4.5 Why the threshold seems more important than smooth relative income

Across the marital satisfaction, divorce, and home-production regressions, the paper controls for

- the wife's continuous income share in the household,
- and the absolute difference in spouses' income ranks.

These controls have little explanatory power relative to the discrete indicator **wifeEarnsMore**.

**Interpretation.** The relevant object is not merely that spouses have unequal earnings. It is that the wife crosses the symbolic threshold of becoming the primary breadwinner.

#### 4.6 Within-couple panel evidence

The PSID panel evidence is especially important because it differences out permanent couple heterogeneity.

- If the wife's income exceeds the husband's, she is less likely to be in the labor force next year.
- The gender gap in housework increases within the same couple.
- Divorce estimates are positive but imprecise, so the panel evidence on divorce is best viewed as suggestive rather than definitive.

**Interpretation.** The panel results make it harder to explain the cross-sectional patterns purely by matching or omitted fixed couple traits.

#### 4.7 Relation to the literature

- **Identity economics.** The paper is a direct application of Akerlof and Kranton's view that deviations from prescribed social roles are costly.
- **Marriage-market economics.** It challenges standard matching, specialization, and bargaining accounts by emphasizing the special role of the breadwinner threshold.
- **Gender and labor supply.** It complements work on gender attitudes by showing that norms affect not only whether women work, but also marriage formation, divorce, and housework.

- **Sociology of home production.** It provides economic evidence consistent with “doing gender” arguments about compensatory housework.

## 5 Tables and figures

### 5.1 Figure I and Figure II: the basic discontinuity

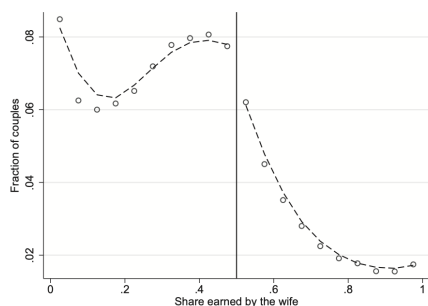


FIGURE I  
Distribution of Relative Income (SIPP Administrative Data)

The data are from the 1990 to 2004 SIPP/SSA/IRS gold standard files. The sample includes married couples where both the husband and wife earn positive income and are between 18 and 65 years of age. For each couple, we use the observation from the first year that the couple is in the panel. Each dot is the fraction of couples in a 0.05 relative income bin. The vertical line indicates the relative income share=0.5. The dashed line is the lowest smoother applied to the distribution allowing for a break at 0.5.

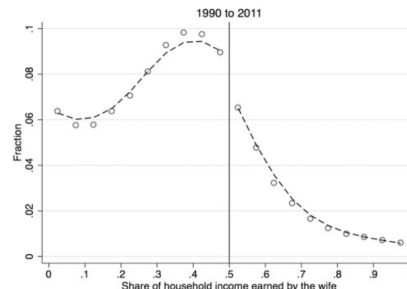


FIGURE II  
Distribution of Relative Income (Census Bureau Data)

The data are from the 1990 and 2000 censuses and 2008 to 2011 ACS single-year files. The sample includes married couples where both the husband and the wife earn positive income and are between 18 and 65 years of age. Each dot is the fraction of couples in a 0.05 relative income bin. The vertical line indicates the relative income share=0.5. The dashed line is the lowest smoother applied to the distribution allowing for a break at 0.5.

- Figure I, based on SIPP administrative earnings, is the foundational fact of the paper.
- There is a sharp drop in the density of the wife’s income share just to the right of 1/2.
- The McCrary test implies a drop of about **12.3%**.
- Figure II shows that after cleaning the Census/ACS income data, the same pattern remains, with a drop of about **13.6%**.

**Read.** The same nonlinearity appears in both administrative and survey-style data. This makes it much less likely that the cliff is a data artifact.

### 5.2 Figure III: evolution over time

- The discontinuity is present in every decade.
- It is largest in 1970, 1980, and 1990, then smaller in 2000 and 2008–2011.
- The paper also reports that the discontinuity is present both with and without children and is already visible among newlyweds.

**Read.** The norm does not disappear as women’s earnings rise. Instead, the data show a persistent threshold effect, though its magnitude weakens somewhat over time.

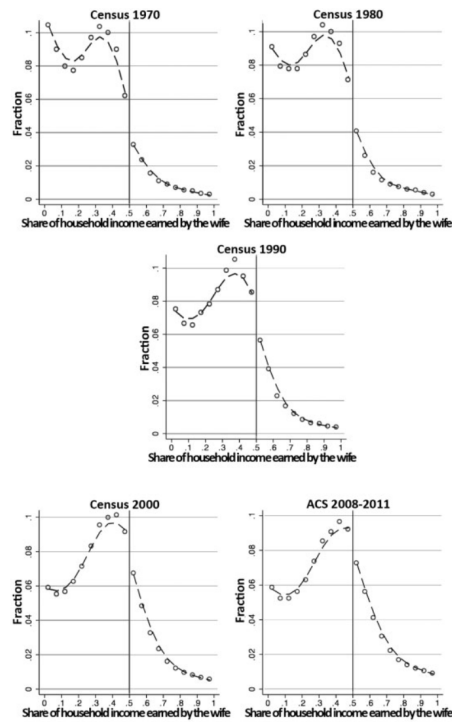


FIGURE III

Distribution of Relative Income over Time (Census Bureau Data)

The data are from the 1970 to 2000 censuses and 2008 to 2011 ACS single-year files. The sample includes married couples where both the husband and the wife earn positive income and are between 18 and 65 years of age. Each dot is the fraction of couples in a 0.05 relative income bin. The vertical line indicates the relative income share=0.5. The dashed line is the lowest smoother applied to the distribution allowing for a break at 0.5.

TABLE I  
POTENTIAL RELATIVE INCOME AND MARRIAGE RATES

|                                   | (1)                                     | (2)                | (3)                  | (4)                  | (5)                  | (6)                  | (7)                  | (8)                 | (9)                |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
|                                   | Actual                                  |                    |                      | Predicted            |                      |                      | Bartik               |                     |                    |
| Income measure:                   | Dependent variable: <i>shareMarried</i> |                    |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |                     |                    |
| <i>PWomanEarnsMore</i>            | -0.080<br>[0.075]                       | -0.046<br>[0.080]  | -0.209***<br>[0.074] | -0.266***<br>[0.068] | -0.252***<br>[0.066] | -0.236***<br>[0.062] | -0.515***<br>[0.189] | -0.343*<br>[0.183]  | -0.351*<br>[0.181] |
| ln Average Women's Income         | 0.055*<br>[0.030]                       | 0.171**<br>[0.071] | 0.088<br>[0.074]     | 0.066*<br>[0.036]    | 0.266**<br>[0.108]   | 0.151<br>[0.108]     | 0.270<br>[0.177]     | 0.943***<br>[0.333] | 0.461<br>[0.371]   |
| ln Average Men's Income           | 0.023<br>[0.032]                        | -0.092<br>[0.070]  | 0.005<br>[0.073]     | -0.001<br>[0.053]    | -0.201**<br>[0.084]  | -0.063<br>[0.093]    | 0.114<br>[0.140]     | -0.558*<br>[0.292]  | -0.097<br>[0.348]  |
| Sex Ratio                         |                                         |                    | -0.030***<br>[0.007] |                      |                      | -0.027***<br>[0.007] |                      |                     | -0.006<br>[0.007]  |
| Female Incarceration Rate         |                                         |                    | -0.369<br>[0.241]    |                      |                      | -0.292<br>[0.232]    |                      |                     | -0.048<br>[0.172]  |
| Male Incarceration Rate           |                                         |                    | 0.433***<br>[0.089]  |                      |                      | 0.210***<br>[0.071]  |                      |                     | 0.056<br>[0.069]   |
| Female Average Years of Education |                                         |                    | 0.009<br>[0.008]     |                      |                      | 0.005<br>[0.007]     |                      |                     | -0.002<br>[0.007]  |
| Male Average Years of Education   |                                         |                    | -0.031***<br>[0.010] |                      |                      | -0.023**<br>[0.008]  |                      |                     | -0.010<br>[0.007]  |
| Number of Females (per million)   |                                         |                    | 0.001<br>[0.005]     |                      |                      | 0.003<br>[0.006]     |                      |                     | -0.003<br>[0.008]  |
| Number of Males (per million)     |                                         |                    | 0.004<br>[0.005]     |                      |                      | 0.002<br>[0.006]     |                      |                     | 0.005<br>[0.007]   |

### 5.3 Table I: marriage-market evidence

- Using actual earnings, the estimated effect of PrWomanEarnsMore on marriage rates is negative and becomes stronger when richer market controls are included.
- Using predicted earnings, the coefficient is stable and strongly negative, around  $-0.24$  to  $-0.27$ .
- Using the Bartik-based distribution, the preferred estimate in column (9) is about  $-0.351$ .
- The authors interpret this as implying that the rise in women’s relative income explains about **29%** of the decline in marriage rates from 1980 to 2010.
- The coefficient is much larger in less-educated marriage markets.

**Read.** Marriage rates are lower in markets where women are more likely to out-earn men, and the pattern is strongest where traditional gender norms are most plausible.

### 5.4 Table II and Table III: labor force participation and realized income

|                                                                       | (1)                                                | (2)                  | (3)                  | (4)                  | (5)                  | (6)                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                                                                       | Dependent variable: <i>Wife in the labor force</i> |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| <i>PrWifeEarnsMore</i>                                                | -0.178***<br>[0.004]                               | -0.142***<br>[0.004] | -0.139***<br>[0.004] | -0.143***<br>[0.004] | -0.148***<br>[0.005] | -0.152***<br>[0.005] |
| Observations                                                          |                                                    | 7,384,176            |                      | 0.145                | 1,375,121            | 1,375,121            |
| R-squared                                                             | 0.097                                              | 0.103                | 0.104                |                      | 0.087                | 0.090                |
| Additional controls:                                                  |                                                    |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| Cubic in <i>lnHusbIncome</i>                                          | no                                                 | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  |
| <i>lnMedianWifePotential</i> × <i>lnHusbIncome</i>                    | no                                                 | no                   | yes                  | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| <i>anyChildren</i>                                                    | no                                                 | no                   | no                   | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| Wife's demographic group × Husband's demographic group                | no                                                 | no                   | no                   | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| <i>PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage</i>                                      | no                                                 | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Vintiles of the wife's and the husband's potential income at marriage | no                                                 | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Marriage duration fixed effects                                       | no                                                 | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Sample restriction                                                    | none                                               | none                 | none                 | none                 | 2010sub              | 2010sub              |

Notes: Data are from the 1970 to 2000 U.S. Census and 2008 to 2011 ACS single-year files. The sample consists of couples where both the wife and the husband are between 18 and 65 years old and the husband is working. The dependent variable *Wife in the labor force* is a binary variable that equals 1 if the wife is in the labor force, 0 otherwise. The key independent variable *PrWifeEarnsMore* is the probability that the wife's income would exceed the husband's if her income were drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in her demographic group. *lnHusbIncome* is the log of husband's income. *lnMedianWifePotential* is the log of the median of the distribution of positive earnings in the wife's demographic group. *anyChildren* is a binary variable that equals 1 if the wife reports having any children, 0 otherwise. *PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage* is the probability that income drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in the wife's demographic group exceeds income drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in the husband's demographic group in the closest census year to the year of their marriage. Marriage duration fixed effects are dummies for the number of years the couple has been married. All regressions include controls for log husband's income, vintiles of the wife's potential income, wife's and husband's education (five categories), wife's and husband's five-year age group, wife's and husband's race (three categories), year, and state fixed effects. Sample restriction "2010sub" indicates a subsample of ACS where the difference between year of marriage and the closest census year is no more than five years and *PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage* could be computed. Standard errors are reported in brackets. \*\*\*Significant at 1% level. \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

|                                                                   | (1)                                  | (2)                  | (3)                  | (4)                  | (5)                  | (6)                  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                                                                   | Dependent variable: <i>IncomeGap</i> |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| <i>PrWifeEarnsMore</i>                                            | -0.031***<br>[0.007]                 | -0.085***<br>[0.006] | -0.095***<br>[0.006] | -0.109***<br>[0.007] | -0.168***<br>[0.009] | -0.178***<br>[0.009] |
| Observations                                                      | 5,306,682                            | 5,306,682            | 5,306,684            | 5,306,664            | 1,049,793            | 1,049,793            |
| R-squared                                                         | 0.004                                | 0.006                | 0.006                | 0.050                | 0.007                | 0.013                |
| Additional controls:                                              |                                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| Cubic in <i>lnHusbIncome</i>                                      | no                                   | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  | yes                  |
| <i>lnMedianWifePotential</i> × <i>lnHusbIncome</i>                | no                                   | no                   | yes                  | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| <i>anyChildren</i>                                                | no                                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| Wife's demographic group × Husband's demographic group            | no                                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  | no                   | no                   |
| <i>PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage</i>                                  | no                                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Vintiles of the wife's and husband's potential income at marriage | no                                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Marriage duration fixed effects                                   | no                                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | no                   | yes                  |
| Sample restriction                                                | none                                 | none                 | none                 | none                 | 2010sub              | 2010sub              |

Notes: Data are from the 1970 to 2000 U.S. Census and 2008 to 2011 ACS single-year files. The sample consists of couples where both the wife and the husband are between 18 and 65 years old and the husband is working. The dependent variable *IncomeGap* measures the difference between the wife's realized and potential earnings. The key independent variable *PrWifeEarnsMore* is the probability that wife's income would exceed the husband's if her income were drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in the wife's demographic group. *lnHusbIncome* is the log of husband's income. *lnMedianWifePotential* is the log of the median of the distribution of positive earnings in the wife's demographic group. *anyChildren* is a binary variable that equals 1 if the wife reports having any children, 0 otherwise. *PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage* is the probability that income drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in the wife's demographic group exceeds income drawn from the distribution of positive earnings in the husband's demographic group in the closest census year to the year of their marriage. Marriage duration fixed effects are dummies for number of years the couple has been married. All regressions include controls for the log of husband's income, vintiles of the wife's potential income, wife's and husband's education (five categories), wife's and husband's five-year age group, wife's and husband's race, year, and state fixed effects. Sample restriction "2010sub" indicates a subsample of ACS where the difference between year of marriage and the closest census year is no more than five years and *PrWifeEarnsMoreAtMarriage* could be computed. Standard errors are reported in brackets. \*\*\*Significant at 1% level, \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

- Table II shows that wives are less likely to be in the labor force when they are more likely to out-earn their husbands.
- The baseline coefficient is about  $-0.178$ ; with richer controls it remains around  $-0.14$  to  $-0.15$ .
- The paper translates this into a roughly **1.4 percentage point** decline in labor force participation for a 10 percentage point increase in the probability of out-earning the husband.
- Table III shows that among working wives, realized earnings fall below potential earnings when the wife is more likely to out-earn her husband.
- The effect is negative and robust, and part of it is explained by fewer hours worked.

**Read.** The norm does not just affect *whether* wives work. It also affects *how much* they earn conditional on working.

### 5.5 Table IV and Table V: marital satisfaction and divorce

- In Table IV, when the wife earns more than the husband, spouses are:

TABLE IV  
RELATIVE INCOME AND MARITAL SATISFACTION

|                                                       | (1)                 | (2)                 | (3)                | (4)                |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| Panel A: dependent variable: <i>happyMarriage</i>     |                     |                     |                    |                    |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                                  | -0.068**<br>[0.031] | -0.060*<br>[0.032]  | -0.070*<br>[0.036] | -0.065*<br>[0.037] |
| Observations                                          | 7,659               | 7,659               | 7,659              | 7,659              |
| R-squared                                             | 0.025               | 0.026               | 0.025              | 0.025              |
| Panel B: dependent variable: <i>marriageTrouble</i>   |                     |                     |                    |                    |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                                  | 0.082***<br>[0.027] | 0.078***<br>[0.029] | 0.079**<br>[0.033] | 0.086**<br>[0.034] |
| Observations                                          | 7,520               | 7,520               | 7,520              | 7,520              |
| R-squared                                             | 0.047               | 0.048               | 0.047              | 0.048              |
| Panel C: dependent variable: <i>discussSeparation</i> |                     |                     |                    |                    |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                                  | 0.068***<br>[0.024] | 0.064***<br>[0.024] | 0.060**<br>[0.028] | 0.065**<br>[0.028] |
| Observations                                          | 7,507               | 7,507               | 7,507              | 7,507              |
| R-squared                                             | 0.034               | 0.034               | 0.034              | 0.034              |
| Additional controls:                                  |                     |                     |                    |                    |
| Cubic in <i>lnWifeIncome</i> and <i>lnHusbIncome</i>  | no                  | yes                 | no                 | no                 |
| <i>relativeIncome</i>                                 | no                  | no                  | yes                | yes                |
| <i> Wife-Husb Income Rank </i>                        | no                  | no                  | no                 | yes                |

Notes. The data are from Wave 1 of the National Survey of Family and Households (NSFH). The sample is restricted to couples where both the wife and the husband are between 18 and 65 years old and at least one person in the household has positive income. The sample includes observations from both husbands and wives. The dependent variables, *happyMarriage*, *marriageTrouble*, and *discussSeparation* are binary variables based on respondents' answers about their marriage (details in the text). *relativeIncome* is the share of the household income earned by the wife. *wifeEarnsMore* is an indicator variable for whether *relativeIncome* > 0.5. *lnWifeIncome* and *lnHusbIncome* are the logs of the wife's and husband's income, respectively. *|Wife-Husb Income Rank|* is the absolute difference in the income ranks of husbands and wives in their respective income distributions. All regressions include the log of the wife's income, log of the husband's income, log of the total household income, a quadratic in wife and husband's age, indicator variables for wife and husband's race and education (five categories), region fixed effects, and an indicator variable for whether only the wife is working or only the husband is working. Each regression includes an indicator variable for whether the wife or the husband is the respondent and have standard errors clustered at the level of the couple. All regressions are weighted using the Wave 1 couple weights from NSFH. Robust standard errors are reported in brackets. \*\*\*significant at 1%, \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

TABLE V  
RELATIVE INCOME AND DIVORCE

|                                                      | (1)                                 | (2)                | (3)              | (4)               |
|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------|------------------|-------------------|
|                                                      | Dependent variable: <i>divorced</i> |                    |                  |                   |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                                 | 0.062**<br>[0.025]                  | 0.060**<br>[0.026] | 0.048<br>[0.030] | 0.051*<br>[0.030] |
| Observations                                         | 3,439                               | 3,439              | 3,439            | 3,439             |
| R-squared                                            | 0.080                               | 0.086              | 0.080            | 0.080             |
| Additional controls:                                 |                                     |                    |                  |                   |
| Cubic in <i>lnWifeIncome</i> and <i>lnHusbIncome</i> | no                                  | yes                | no               | no                |
| <i>relativeIncome</i>                                | no                                  | no                 | yes              | yes               |
| <i> Wife-Husb Income Rank </i>                       | no                                  | no                 | no               | yes               |

Notes. The data are from Waves 1 and 2 of the National Survey of Family and Households (NSFH). The sample is restricted to couples where both the wife and the husband are between 18 and 65 years old (in Wave 1) and at least one person in the household has positive income. The dependent variable *divorced* is an indicator for whether the couple is divorced or separated as of Wave 2. *relativeIncome* is the share of the household income earned by the wife. *wifeEarnsMore* is an indicator variable for whether *relativeIncome* > 0.5. *lnWifeIncome* and *lnHusbIncome* are the logs of the wife's and husband's income, respectively. *|Wife-Husb Income Rank|* is the absolute difference in the income ranks of husbands and wives in their respective income distributions. All regressions include the log of the wife's income, log of the husband's income, log of the total household income, a quadratic in wife and husband's age, indicator variables for wife and husband's race and education (five categories), region fixed effects, and an indicator variable for whether only the wife is working or only the husband is working. All regressions are weighted using the Wave 1 couple weights from NSFH. Robust standard errors are reported in brackets. \*\*\*significant at 1%, \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

- about **7 percentage points** less likely to report a very happy marriage,
- about **8 percentage points** more likely to report marital trouble,
- about **6 percentage points** more likely to discuss separation.
- These effects survive controls for smooth relative income and for absolute differences in spouses' income ranks.
- Table V shows that the wife earning more than the husband raises divorce/separation probability by about **5–6 percentage points**, though the specification with smooth relative-income controls is somewhat less precise.

**Read.** The wife crossing the husband's earnings threshold is associated with meaningful deterioration in marriage quality and a sizable increase in breakup risk.

## 5.6 Table VI: home production

- The key coefficient is on **female** × **wifeEarnsMore**.
- Once the specification controls for smooth relative income, the estimate becomes large and positive: roughly **2.2 to 2.3 hours** more nonmarket work per week.
- The effect is especially visible for **chores**.

**Read.** Standard comparative-advantage logic says that a wife who earns more should do *less* housework. The paper finds the opposite once the breadwinner threshold is crossed.



TABLE VI  
RELATIVE INCOME AND THE GENDER GAP IN NONMARKET WORK

|                                                      | (1)                                                              | (2)               | (3)                 | (4)                 | (5)                               | (6)                 |
|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------|---------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------|
|                                                      | Dependent variable: <i>Total nonmarket work (hours per week)</i> |                   |                     |                     |                                   |                     |
| <i>female</i> × <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                 | 1.087<br>[0.740]                                                 | 1.263*<br>[0.762] | 2.183***<br>[0.782] | 2.297***<br>[0.756] | 2.961***<br>[0.844]               | 2.757***<br>[0.998] |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i>                                 | 0.460<br>[0.523]                                                 | 0.132<br>[0.544]  | -0.031<br>[0.557]   | -0.147<br>[0.538]   | -0.546<br>[0.600]                 | -0.439<br>[0.707]   |
| Observations                                         | 37,665                                                           | 37,665            | 37,665              | 37,665              | 22,390                            | 18,227              |
| R-squared                                            | 0.233                                                            | 0.233             | 0.234               | 0.285               | 0.224                             | 0.375               |
| Additional controls:                                 |                                                                  |                   |                     |                     |                                   |                     |
| Cubic in <i>lnWifeIncome</i> and <i>lnHusbIncome</i> | no                                                               | yes               | yes                 | yes                 | yes                               | yes                 |
| <i>relativeIncome</i>                                | no                                                               | no                | yes                 | yes                 | yes                               | yes                 |
| Children controls                                    | no                                                               | no                | no                  | yes                 | yes                               | yes                 |
| Sample restriction                                   | none                                                             | none              | none                | none                | both spouses have positive income | week-day only       |

Notes. Data source are ATUS/CPS from 2003 to 2011. The sample is restricted to married individuals who are between 18 and 65 years old and whose spouse is also between 18 and 65 years old. The sample is further restricted to couples where both spouses are present at the time of the ATUS interview, and where at least one of the spouses is employed at the time of the ATUS interview. *wifeIncome* (*husbandIncome*) is the wife's (husband's) weekly earnings at main job. Earnings are drawn from the ATUS interview for the spouse that completes that interview and from the CPS interview for the other spouse; earnings from the CPS interview are changed to 0 if that spouse is not working at the time of the ATUS interview. *relativeIncome* is the share of the household income earned by the wife. The key independent variable *wifeEarnsMore* is an indicator variable for whether *relativeIncome* > 0.5. "Children controls" include indicator variables for whether the respondent has no children, whether the youngest child is 3 or younger, between 4 and 6, or is older than 6. All regressions include the log of the wife's income, log of the husband's income, log of the total household income, year, state, and day of the week fixed effects, the wife and the husband's race, a quadratic in wife and husband's age, indicator variables for the wife's and the husband's education groups (five categories), and indicator variables for whether only the husband is working, and whether only the wife is working. The specifications also include the interaction of all these controls with an indicator variable for whether the ATUS respondent is female. The estimated coefficients on female ATUS respondent in a regression that includes the same controls as in column (2) but only interacts *wifeEarnsMore* with female ATUS respondents are, respectively: 16.70 [0.26] (nonmarket work + childcare); 11.00 [0.22] (nonmarket work). Each observation is weighted using the ATUS/CPS weight. Standard errors are reported in brackets. \*\*\*significant at 1% level, \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

## 5.7 Table VII: panel evidence

| TABLE VII<br>RELATIVE INCOME AND LABOR FORCE PARTICIPATION, DIVORCE, AND GENDER GAP IN HOUSEWORK, PANEL DATA EVIDENCE |                                                         |                      |                      |                      |                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                                                                                                                       | (1)                                                     | (2)                  | (3)                  | (4)                  | (5)                  |
| Panel A: relative income and labor force participation                                                                |                                                         |                      |                      |                      |                      |
|                                                                                                                       | Dependent variable: <i>Wife in the labor force in t</i> |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i> in $t-1$                                                                                         | -0.019***<br>[0.004]                                    | -0.018***<br>[0.004] | -0.013***<br>[0.004] | -0.012***<br>[0.004] | -0.014***<br>[0.003] |
| Observations                                                                                                          | 110,123                                                 | 110,123              | 110,123              | 110,123              | 110,123              |
| R-squared                                                                                                             | 0.718                                                   | 0.720                | 0.720                | 0.721                | 0.662                |
| Panel B: relative income and marital stability                                                                        |                                                         |                      |                      |                      |                      |
|                                                                                                                       | Dependent variable: <i>Divorced in t</i>                |                      |                      |                      |                      |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i> in $t-1$                                                                                         | 0.003<br>[0.002]                                        | 0.003<br>[0.003]     | 0.004<br>[0.003]     | 0.004<br>[0.003]     | 0.000<br>[0.003]     |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i> in $t-2$                                                                                         | 0.005*<br>[0.003]                                       | 0.005*<br>[0.003]    | 0.005<br>[0.003]     | 0.005<br>[0.003]     | 0.002<br>[0.003]     |
| Observations                                                                                                          | 72,169                                                  | 72,169               | 72,169               | 72,169               | 72,169               |
| R-squared                                                                                                             | 0.418                                                   | 0.418                | 0.418                | 0.418                | 0.013                |

| TABLE VII<br>(CONTINUED)                                |                                                                         |                   |                     |                     |                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
|                                                         | (1)                                                                     | (2)               | (3)                 | (4)                 | (5)                 |
| Panel C: relative income and gender gap in housework    |                                                                         |                   |                     |                     |                     |
|                                                         | Dependent variable: <i>Wife housework in t - Husband housework in t</i> |                   |                     |                     |                     |
| <i>wifeEarnsMore</i> in $t$                             | 0.059<br>[0.256]                                                        | 0.464*<br>[0.261] | 1.048***<br>[0.275] | 0.904***<br>[0.273] | 1.141***<br>[0.310] |
| Observations                                            | 67,603                                                                  | 67,603            | 67,603              | 67,603              | 67,603              |
| R-squared                                               | 0.586                                                                   | 0.587             | 0.587               | 0.595               | 0.376               |
| Additional controls:                                    |                                                                         |                   |                     |                     |                     |
| Couple fixed effects                                    | yes                                                                     | yes               | yes                 | yes                 | no                  |
| Cubic in <i>lnWifeIncome</i> and <i>lnHusbandIncome</i> | no                                                                      | yes               | yes                 | yes                 | yes                 |
| <i>relativeIncome</i>                                   | no                                                                      | no                | yes                 | yes                 | yes                 |
| Children controls                                       | no                                                                      | no                | no                  | yes                 | yes                 |

Notes. The data are from the PHD, 1989 to 2009. See Online Appendix for sample construction for each panel. The sample is restricted to couples where both the wife and the husband are between 18 and 65 years of age and where at least one of the spouses is working in the year income and relative income measures are used in the regression. *Wife in the labor force in t* is a dummy variable that equals 1 if the wife is in the labor force at time  $t$ , 0 otherwise. *Divorced in t* is a dummy variable that equals 1 if the couple is divorced or separated at time  $t$ , 0 otherwise. *Wife housework in t - Husband housework in t* is the difference between the wife's and the husband's weekly hours of home production at time  $t$ . *Wife housework in t* is the wife's weekly hours of home production at time  $t$ . *Husband housework in t* is the husband's weekly hours of home production at time  $t$ . *wifeEarnsMore in t* is an indicator variable that equals 1 if *relativeIncome* > 0.5 at time  $t$ . *relativeIncome* is the share of the household income earned by the wife. *lnWifeIncome* is the log of the wife's labor market earnings. *lnHusbandIncome* is the log of the husband's labor market earnings. "Children controls" include indicator variables for whether the respondent has no children, whether the youngest child is 3 or younger, between 4 and 6, older than 6. All regressions include the log of the wife's income, the log of the husband's income, the log of the couple's income, an indicator for whether only the wife is working, an indicator for whether only the husband is working, a quadratic in wife's and husband's age, year fixed effects and state fixed effects. All independent variables related to income in a regression (including whether only the wife is working or whether only the husband is working) are measured in the same year or years as *WifeEarnsMore* in that regression. Standard errors are clustered at the couple level and are reported in brackets. \*\*\*significant at 1% level, \*\*at 5%, \*at 10%.

- Panel A: if the wife earned more than the husband in  $t-1$ , she is about **1.8 to 1.9 percentage points** less likely to be in the labor force in  $t$ ; with relative-income controls, the effect is still about **1.2 to 1.3 percentage points**.
- Panel B: lagged wife-out-earns-husband indicators predict more divorce, but the coefficients are imprecise.
- Panel C: within a given couple, when the wife earns more than the husband, the wife-housework minus husband-housework gap increases by roughly **one hour per week**.

**Read.** The panel results are crucial because they show that these patterns are not just about different kinds of couples selecting into different earnings configurations.

## 6 Short summary

- **Method.** Use a discontinuity in the distribution of relative earnings, market-level regressions, household-level regressions, time-use data, and panel fixed-effects evidence to study the consequences of gender identity.
- **Identification.** Standard models imply continuity around equal spousal earnings; the sharp break at the wife-breadwinner threshold, stronger among less-educated couples and supported by Bartik variation and within-couple evidence, points to gender norms.

- **Application.** U.S. marriage formation, labor supply, marital stability, and housework from multiple household datasets.
- **Main result.** The norm that a husband should earn more than his wife appears to affect who marries, whether wives work, how much they earn, how happy marriages are, how likely they are to end, and how household chores are divided.

## 7 Conclusion

### 7.1 Core conclusion (what the paper establishes)

- The paper establishes that relative income inside households matters in a sharply **nonlinear** way.
- The threshold where the wife starts earning more than the husband has special behavioral significance.
- This threshold is linked to lower marriage rates, reduced female labor supply, lower realized female earnings conditional on work, more marital instability, and more housework by wives.

### 7.2 Economic intuition

- A gender identity norm creates a cost when the wife becomes the primary breadwinner.
- Couples may respond on several margins:
  - avoid matching into such unions,
  - reduce the wife’s labor force participation,
  - compress the wife’s earnings conditional on work,
  - reallocate chores toward the wife,
  - or dissolve the marriage when the norm is violated.
- Because these responses happen inside the household, they can distort both labor-market outcomes and family outcomes.

### 7.3 Takeaway

This paper is important because it shows that slow-moving social norms can create a household-level “glass ceiling” even when women have the human capital to earn more than men. The main lesson is that progress in women’s market opportunities does not mechanically translate into equal household outcomes: norms about who should be the breadwinner can offset part of that progress through marriage choices, labor-supply distortions, and compensatory behavior at home.